Jairam's successor as environment minister, Jayanthi Natarajan, proved equally controversial. If Jairam would strike down projects, Jayanthi was accused of sitting on files. Her detracto in the power corridors alleged that she was a 'rent-seeking' minister who had to be bribed for clearances, with her OSD (officer on special duty) Gayatri Devi being the supposed go-between (Modi in a campaign speech would later refer to a 'Jayanthi tax'). When I asked her for a response to the charges on a television programme, she had angrily dismissed it as 'a tissue of lies'.

On 21 December 2013, hours before Rahul Gandhi was to address a FICCI audience, Jayanthi was removed as the environment minister. Publicly, the fourth-generation Congresswoman from Tamil Nadu (her grandfather had been chief minister) kept silent on her removal. Privately, she was seething. Interestingly, Jayanthi had been close to Rajiv Gandhi. She had been in Sriperumbudur when the former prime minister was assassinated. But with Rahul, the equation was different. She was once pulled up by a Rahul aide and asked to change her Kanjivaram sari on a TV programme because it had a lotus symbol along the border!

Jairam and Jayanthi, though, were sideshows. Corporate India's greater disenchantment was with the prime minister himself. Manmohan Singh, after all, had always been much admired by India Inc. since his path-breaking budget of 1991. They had once been his biggest cheerleaders. Now, they wanted him out. And soon. 'Our financial bottom lines were bleeding and yet the government was happy to keep announcing large-scale subsidies. Manmohanomics was over, and we were dealing with Sonianomics,' said one corporate leader to me. Another lamented, 'Surely, when Pranab Mukherjee brought in the retrospective tax in the 2012 budget, the prime minister knew it would send the wrong signal to business. Yet, he just kept quiet.'

The retrospective tax, in particular, was seen to symbolize corporate India's discomfiture with the UPA government. It had been introduced in the 2012 budget to virtually force the UK-based telecom giant Vodafone to pay Rs 11,000 crore in tax for acquiring the India business of another telecom company, Hutchison, in 2007. The Supreme Court had ruled that